Wednesday, November 4, 2026

St. Charles Borromeo

Bishop, Archbishop of Milan · Feast, November 4



Portrait of St. Charles Borromeo, Ottavio Bizzozzero, c. 1680, Ospedale Maggiore, Milan[1]

1. Ottavio Bizzozzero, *Portrait of St. Charles Borromeo*, oil on canvas, c. 1680, collections of the Ospedale Maggiore, Milan.

✠ The Essentials

- **Origin:** the Castle of Arona, on the southern shore of Lake Maggiore in northern Italy.[2] His father was Count Giberto Borromeo and his mother Margherita de' Medici;[3] her brother became Pope Pius IV in 1559.[4]
- **Born:** October 2, 1538[5]
- **Died:** November 3, 1584, in Milan,[6] of a fever that came on while he was visiting his diocese. He kept saying Mass and giving Communion while sick,[7] and said Mass for the last time on All Saints' Day.[8]
- **Canonized:** November 1, 1610, by Pope Paul V, who fixed his feast on November 4.[9]
- **Motto:** his emblem was the word *Humilitas* (humility), crowned.[10]

✠ His Life in Brief

Charles earned his doctorate in civil and canon law in 1559.[11] When his uncle became Pope Pius IV, he called Charles to Rome and in January 1560 made him a cardinal.[12] As papal secretary of state

---

2. "St. Charles Borromeo," in *The Catholic Encyclopedia*, vol. 3 (New York: Robert Appleton Company, 1908).
3. Ibid.
4. Ibid.
5. Ibid.
6. Ibid.
7. Ibid.
8. Ibid.
9. Ibid.
10. Ibid.
11. Ibid.
12. Ibid.

Charles worked to reconvene the suspended Council of Trent, and the Catholic Encyclopedia credits its reassembly largely to his patience and devotion.[13] In 1563, under family pressure to leave the clerical state and marry, he had himself secretly ordained a priest instead.[14]

- After the Council he worked on the catechism that embodied its teaching (the Roman Catechism).[15]
- In 1565 he entered Milan as its first resident archbishop in eighty years.[16] He opened a seminary[17] and began the work of the Confraternity of Christian Doctrine so that children would be carefully taught the faith.[18]
- In October 1569 a member of the Humiliati, an order resisting his reforms, fired at him while he knelt at evening prayer; the ball did not even pierce his clothes.[19]
- When plague struck Milan in 1576, he hurried back to the city, visited the plague-stricken houses and hospital himself,[20] and walked in procession barefoot with a rope around his neck, doing penance for his people.[21]

13. Ibid.
14. Ibid.
15. Ibid.
16. Ibid.
17. Ibid.
18. Ibid.
19. Ibid.
20. Ibid.
21. Ibid.

✠ Famous Excerpt: from his sermon at his last synod (Office of Readings, November 4)

> *"If teaching and preaching is your job, then study diligently and apply yourself to whatever is necessary for doing the job well. Be sure that you first preach by the way you live. If you do not, people will notice that you say one thing, but live otherwise, and your words will bring only cynical laughter and a derisive shake of the head. Are you in charge of a parish? If so, do not neglect the parish of your own soul, do not give yourself to others so completely that you have nothing left for yourself."*[22]

> *"My brothers, you must realise that for us churchmen nothing is more necessary than meditation. We must meditate before, during and after everything we do."*[23]

✠ 1. Catechesis

Lesson: why we have catechisms. The Catechism of the Catholic Church itself names Charles: after the Council of Trent, "thanks to the work of holy bishops and theologians such as St. Peter Canisius, St. Charles Borromeo, St. Turibius of Mongrovejo or St. Robert Bellarmine, it occasioned the publication of numerous catechisms" (CCC 9).[24] "The ministry of catechesis draws ever fresh energy from the councils" (CCC 9).[25] The Catholic Encyclopedia calls his work with the Confraternity of Christian Doctrine "really the beginning of what is now known as the Sunday school."[26]

---

22. Charles Borromeo, Sermon at his last synod, *Acta Ecclesiae Mediolanensis* (Milan, 1599), 1177–78; English in *The Liturgy of the Hours*, Office of Readings, November 4.
23. Ibid.
24. *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, 2nd ed. (Vatican City: Libreria Editrice Vaticana, 1997), no. 9.
25. Ibid.
26. "St. Charles Borromeo," *Catholic Encyclopedia*.

For catechists, his sermon is the best lesson: "Be sure that you first preach by the way you live."[27]

✠ 2. Apologetics

Objection: "The Catholic Church was too corrupt to reform itself; only the Protestant Reformation fixed it." Concede what is true: there were real abuses, and Milan had gone eighty years without a resident archbishop.[28] The Church itself says she is "at once holy and always in need of purification" and that "all members of the Church, including her ministers, must acknowledge that they are sinners" (CCC 827).[29][30] But reform came from inside the Church. The Catholic Encyclopedia sums up Charles's work this way: he "showed admirably how the Church had the power to reform from within."[31] He began with the bishops and himself: "We ought to walk in front, and our spiritual subjects will follow us more easily."[32] That is the pattern of Scripture as well: "set an example for those who believe, in speech, conduct, love, faith, and purity" (1 Tim 4:12).

✠ 3. Theology

- **The holiness and renewal of the Church:** The Collect for his feast asks that "your Church may be constantly renewed and, by conforming herself to the likeness of Christ, may show his face

27. Borromeo, Sermon at his last synod.
28. "St. Charles Borromeo," *Catholic Encyclopedia*.
29. *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, 2nd ed. (Vatican City: Libreria Editrice Vaticana, 1997), no. 827.
30. Ibid.
31. "St. Charles Borromeo," *Catholic Encyclopedia*.
32. Ibid.

to the world."[33] Renewal, in this view, is conformity to Christ, not invention.

- **Prayer and pastoral work:** For Charles, meditation is not a retreat from ministry but its source: "nothing is more necessary than meditation. We must meditate before, during and after everything we do."[34]
- **The shepherd who stays:** In the plague he returned to his people and went to the sick himself.[35] The good shepherd "lays down his life for the sheep" (Jn 10:11).

✠ 4. Devotional Prayer

Collect for St. Charles Borromeo (Roman Missal, November 4):[36]
Preserve in the midst of your people, we ask, O Lord, the spirit with which you filled the Bishop Saint Charles Borromeo, that your Church may be constantly renewed and, by conforming herself to the likeness of Christ, may show his face to the world. Who lives and reigns with you in the unity of the Holy Spirit, God, for ever and ever. Amen.

Practice: Before your work today, take a few minutes to pray first, as Charles urged: "before, during and after everything we do."[37] Pray for your bishop and your parish priests.

---

33. *The Roman Missal*, 3rd typical ed., English trans. (ICEL, 2011), Proper of Saints, November 4, Saint Charles Borromeo, Collect.
34. Borromeo, Sermon at his last synod.
35. "St. Charles Borromeo," *Catholic Encyclopedia*.
36. *The Roman Missal*, 3rd typical ed., English trans. (ICEL, 2011), Proper of Saints, November 4, Saint Charles Borromeo, Collect.
37. Borromeo, Sermon at his last synod.

✠ Today's Takeaway

Reform starts with the reformer. "Be sure that you first preach by the way you live."[38]

St. Charles Borromeo, pray for us.

38. Ibid.